

during this exercise. Remember that we all make mistakes, but ask yourself whether or not you knew that you were making the wrong choice at the time. For example, when I think about some of the spending decisions that I made when my relationship with money was at rock bottom, I recognize that I knew that I was creating problems for myself even as I was buying things – I just wasn't thinking of the longer-term consequences. I also see quite clearly now that I didn't feel that I was deserving of a good relationship with money and healthy finances, so many of my decisions were related to low self-esteem and a feeling of being undeserving. I also recognize that many more were due to a lack of patience and self-discipline, which enables me to identify areas that I might still need to work on, or at least watch out for. Forgiving yourself and knowing yourself – recognizing that you are flawed and a constant work-in-progress, as everybody is, go hand in hand.

Eventually, as you work through these mistakes, you will reach a point where you have to let it go. Guilt can be a useful emotion when it acts as a deterrent for repeating or participating in certain behaviours, but when we cling to it for too long, it can have the opposite effect. Remember to hold on to it only for as long as it's useful.